OPERATOR LAYER

THE RADIO INDUSTRY INSIDER DECODER

The mechanics nobody explains to independents

How ratings work, how a station’s clock is built, when adds happen, and how the promotion industry moves music.

EXECUTIVE BRIEFING · PREMIUM FLOOR

RADIOREACH.US · THE RADIO OWNERSHIP SYSTEM

THE ADD → CHART → CASCADE LOOP

SERVICE	→	ADDS	→	CHART	→	SECOND WAVE
send the record		work the list week after week		report spins · climb		pitch bigger with proof

Labels pay $2,000–10,000 per record to run the machine you will run yourself.

DECODER · THE RATINGS ENGINE

THE RADIO INDUSTRY INSIDER DECODER

The mechanics nobody explains to independent artists: how ratings work, how a station's clock is built, when adds actually happen, and how the promotion industry moves music. Read this once. Reference it forever. This is the difference between guessing and operating.

---

1. HOW RADIO IS ACTUALLY MEASURED (THE RATINGS ENGINE)

Every commercial station is fighting for one currency: **listenership**, measured by Nielsen Audio.

- **PPM markets (≈ top 48 metros):** people wear a Portable People Meter that logs listening minute by minute — every quarter-hour, every daypart, every station change. PPM stations have real data on exactly when their audience spikes. This is why drive-time and daypart fit matter so much: a station knows precisely which slots have the ears.
- **Diary markets (the rest of the country):** listeners write down what they heard in a diary. Coarser, moodier, and influenced by how memorable a station is. In diary markets, a song's **catchiness and station branding** matter disproportionately — because a listener has to remember to write your station down.
- **"The book" / book periods:** ratings are delivered in quarterly "books" (PPM markets get monthly data). Stations run "ratings weeks" — typically the **last two weeks of each book period** — when programming gets conservative: fewer risks, more proven hits. Believing you can break an unknown during a ratings week is amateur thinking. Launch around book starts, not book ends.
- **The metrics that matter to a PD: cume** (how many unique people heard the station) and **AQH** (average quarter-hour audience). Songs are inventory that either grows cume (a hit brings new listeners) or holds AQH (a familiar track keeps people from tuning away). Your pitch should answer one of those two jobs — not "this song is good."

Insider translation: the PD's yes is a ratings bet. The format, the clock, and the slot matter more than your artistry. Serve the bet and you win the slot.

---

2. THE CLOCK — HOW AN HOUR IS REALLY BUILT

Every hour of radio is a **clock**: a fixed skeleton of intros, current hits, recurrents, golds, local breaks, sweepers, and legal IDs. A PD literally has a printed clock sheet.

The rotation categories (record pools that a song lives in):

Category	Life	Spins/week (typical)	Job

POWER	New heavy	30–50+	Carry the ratings
MEDIUM	Established current	15–30	Hold the hour
LIGHT	Fading current	5–15	Transition out
RECURRENT	6–18 months old	Varies	Familiarity
GOLD	Catalog	Varies	Cume/faithful

What this means for you: you don't need to be a power record to win — you need to be a current. The fastest win for an unknown is a specialty slot (night, weekend, local-focus), then get upgraded from specialty to medium by proving reaction. That ladder — specialty → medium → power — is the industry's actual entry ramp, and it's almost never explained because the artists who know it don't share it.

Insider move: when a PD says "it's in light rotation," that's not a no — that's a category. Your job becomes a **rotation upgrade**, which is a much smaller ask: send listener-feedback receipts, ticket data, and stream spikes until the song graduates.

---

3. ADD CYCLES — WHEN STATIONS ACTUALLY SAY YES

Radio doesn't decide daily. It decides on **cycles**:

- **Commercial stations:** most formats have set "add dates" — often **Tuesdays** (matches new-music Tuesday and the industry's weekly cadence), though formats differ (some add Monday, some Friday, country historically Tuesday). The promo industry calls a record's big date an **"impact date."** Pitch timing is built around the add day, not around your release day.
- **College and community stations:** music directors add on their own **weekly cycles** during business hours. College rotation is refreshed weekly — which means a Friday pitch gets heard Monday, and a Monday pitch can make the next rotation list.
- **Ratings weeks:** the "no new music" window. Don't pitch an unknown into the last two weeks of a book unless you're already in rotation.

Insider move: ask the question that unlocks the calendar: "What's your add cycle — and what day does rotation news go out?" You're not asking for airplay; you're asking for their operational schedule. That question alone separates you from 99% of emails, and the answer tells you exactly when to send.

---

4. THE COLLEGE RADIO MACHINE (THE BEST KEPT LANE)

College radio is not "lesser" — it's the only radio format with **structural hunger**: DJs and music directors who actively want new music, weekly rotation updates, and measurable charts.

- **The charts are real, public, and trackable.** The **NACC 200** (North American College Chart) and **RMR** (Radio Monitor, the college airplay ranker) are the reporting lanes that labels and supervisors actually watch. Getting on the chart is how an unknown becomes "charting" — and "charting at college radio" is the single most undervalued proof line in independent music.
- **The rep-network shortcut:** college radio promotion is commonly run through **college rep networks** — teams of student and regional reps who pitch stations, track adds, and report spins for a weekly fee. Labels use them for a reason: college stations respond to personal reps far better than email.
- **Why it matters to you:** college adds are cheap, fast, and they feed the NACC chart, which is verifiable proof for the commercial pitch, the sync license, and the sponsor deck.

Insider move: you don't need a rep network to get the first 10 adds — you need the heat map, the specialty hunt, and the weekly cycle. But once you're charting, a rep network can scale the lane — and that's exactly what the Empire Loop (Module 6) is built to feed.

5. HOW THE PROMOTION INDUSTRY ACTUALLY MOVES MUSIC

The label promotion machine, in order:

1. **Service the record** — send the music + one-page brief to the station list through delivery platforms or direct link. (This is your Module 3 payload.)
2. **Adds campaign** — an independent promo rep (or label staff) works the list week after week: calls, emails, playlist check-ins, spin tracking. The rep's whole job is **adds and rotation upgrades.**
3. **Chart week** — every week, stations report plays to chart services (Mediabase for commercial; NACC/RMR for college). The rep aggregates, reports, and the record climbs or stalls.
4. **Second wave** — once a record is charting, the rep pitches it to bigger stations with evidence: "charting at college, 40 stations, trending in [markets]." Proof converts cold lists into warm ones.

What this means for an independent: you can run a condensed version of this machine solo — which is exactly what this course teaches. The code word for the whole system: **the Add → Chart → Cascade loop.** Labels pay $2,000–$10,000 per record for what you're about to run yourself.

6. THE INSIDER GLOSSARY (DEFINITIONS THAT CHANGE PITCHES)

Term	Meaning	Why it matters
Add	Station adds the record to rotation	The core win
Spin	One play	The measurable unit
Rotation	Category a song lives in (power/medium/light/current/recurrent/gold)	Skews every follow-up ask
Impact date	The planned first add date	Timing weapon
Current	A new song in rotation	Your target category
Specialty show	Genre/locale/themed show with a dedicated host	Fastest entry for unknowns
Clock	The hour's fixed skeleton	Where your song needs to fit
Cume / AQH	Unique listeners / avg quarter-hour audience	The ratings currency
PPM / Diary	Meter vs. written-listener measurement	Why daypart and memorability matter
Book / ratings week	Ratings period (quarterly)	Kill window for new music
NACC 200	College radio chart	Verifiable proof engine
RMR	Radio Monitor — college airplay reporting	Same, second lane
Mediabase / BDS	Commercial spin data services	Supervisors and labels check these
Rep network	College radio promo teams	Scale lever for the college lane
Clean edit	Explicit-free version	Required for daytime lanes
Radio edit	Shortened/hooked version	Required for commercial clocks
Service	Sending the record to the list	Step one of every campaign
Rotation upgrade	Moving a song up a category	The art of the follow-up

7. THE 10 INSIDER RULES (MEMORIZE)

1. A PD’s yes is a **ratings bet**, not a taste vote.
2. Serve the **clock**, not the ego — 3:00–3:45, hook inside 12 seconds, clean edit ready.
3. **Specialty → medium → power** is the entry ladder. Never skip rungs.
4. **Tuesday add cycles and weekly college cycles** are your scheduling spine.
5. **Never pitch during ratings weeks** to a station that doesn’t know you.
6. College **charting is proof** — NACC/RMR are real, public, and supervisors read them.
7. The industry moves music in **four phases: service → adds → chart → second wave.** Run all four.
8. **Rotation categories are asks**: light → medium is a smaller, winnable battle than unknown → power.
9. **Spins are merchandise** — every spin is a data point you can sell (sync, sponsorship, booking).
10. Labels pay for what you’re building — the machine is the product.

Insider Layer · Frequency Dominion · paired with Modules 1–6 Insider Playbooks